Simon Says (is Not a Game)

by Ashley Davis and Lakiyra Williams (aka Oompa)

You know how it goes . . .

When Simon says do an action, you do an action

But only do an action if Simon says . . . Ready?

Simon Says: Raise your right hand

Simon Says: Put your right hand down

Simon Says: Raise your left hand

Put your left hand down

Oh, y'all look good . . . okay

INTRODUCTION

The game has begun. It looks harmless. After all, in elementary school, Simon Says is used to promote listening skills. But beneath the laughter, Simon Says quietly builds habits that mirror survival in prison: constant vigilance, strict obedience, and the suppression of personal needs.

Through repetition and authority, the poem will challenge you to question how environments meant to educate can instead condition students to accept confinement, tracing a disturbing line between learning to listen and learning to submit.

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Simon Says: Put your left hand down

Now cross your arms.

No, Simon didn't say cross your arms

You need to make sure you're listening.

Okay, Simon Says: Smile. Show us your teeth.

You're only as valuable as you are able.

Simon Says: Raise your right hand again

Wave.

Why are you waving?

You don't know how to listen.

You must not be a good listener at home.

Simon Says: It's not time for a bathroom break.

You go when Simon says;

Eat when Simon says;

Leave this room when Simon says.

There's only one rule: Only do what Simon says

Simon Says: Only speak when you are told to speak.

Simon Says: Speak to your neighbor.

Now why isn't everyone speaking?

You chose to play this game,

Now you're choosing not to play . . .

How dare you ruin it for everyone else!

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Simon Says: Still not time for a bathroom break

And stop asking.

Simon Says: You're not listening.

People that don't listen will never be successful.

You know what? They don't even care!

Just take out a book and shut up. Read.

Simon Says: Read.

Simon Says: It's time to file into the hallway now

One behind the other;

Straight silent line, tight to the right.

Simon Says: If you can't be silent,

How will you hear what Simon is telling you to do?

Silence! I said be silent!

Simon Says: **Be silent!**

Simon Says: Only 20 minutes to eat your lunch and

Be silent.

Eat faster! Eat faster!

Simon Says: Sit up straight and be still.

Simon Says: Tuck in your uniform.

You don't want to tuck in your uniform?

Go sit in the corner!

Simon Says: If you can't handle this classroom,

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How will you handle your jail cell?

Simon Says: You will refer to it as Officer Simon from here on.

And Officer Simon Says: Know your place.

Officer Simon Says: Show your teeth, boy.

You're only as valuable as you are able.

Officer Simon Says: Put your hand down.

We don't raise hands here.

There are no questions here.

Officer Simon Says: You must not be a good listener at home.

At this rate you'll not be going back home.

Officer Simon Says: You will speak only when you are told to speak

Officer Simon Says: Speak to your cell mate.

Now, why aren't you speaking?

You chose to play this game;

Now you're choosing not to play.

How dare you ruin it for everyone else.

Officer Simon Says: It's still not time for a bathroom break

Stop asking!

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Officer Simon Says: **You're not listening!**

People that don't listen will never be successful

Officer Simon Says: It's time to file into the hallway

again.

One behind the other

Straight silent line. Tight to the right.

Officer Simon Says: If you can't be silent,

How will you hear what Officer Simon is telling you to

do?

Silence! I said be silent!

Officer Simon Says: **Be silent!**

Fix your uniform!

Fix your face when you're talking to me!

Clean your bunk, you animal.

Sit up straight!

I don't care if I didn't say Officer Simon Says.

Officer Simon said it, so sit up straight and be still!

Be still!

Be still!

Officer Simon Says: If you can't handle your jail cell,

How will you handle your casket?

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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